MODULE 34 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

What Changed Since the Guide

Every change from July to October 2026 that touches the exam, dated and checked against Anthropic's release notes, with the exam-safe way to answer.

SCOPE All seven domains FOCUS Changes since July 2026 MODULE 34 of 38

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A road atlas from July still shows every road. It does not show this week's diversions. **Navigate by the roads. Check the diversions.**

How to answer when the platform has moved

- **Principles did not change:** constraints first, least privilege, evaluate before switching, human authority.
- **Details did:** model names, parameters, protocol versions, defaults.
- **Answer with the principle** the question is testing.
- **Use a changed detail** only to rule out an option that could no longer work.
- **Never pick an option** just because it names the newest feature.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If an option relies on a removed parameter, it was rarely the principled answer anyway.

Models, July to October 2026

DATE	CHANGE
24 Jul	Claude Opus 5 launched
1 Sep	Fable 5.1 and Mythos 5.1 launched; Mythos has limited availability
22 Sep	Opus 5.5 launched: 1M context; thinking cannot be disabled
28 Sep	Sonnet 5.5 launched
7 Oct	Haiku 5.5 launched: 1M context, 128K output
30 Nov	Sonnet 4.5 retires (announced 30 Sep)

EXAM-SAFE

Choose by requirements and evaluation results, never by name or launch date.

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API behaviour that changed

CHANGE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
Forced tool_choice (any, tool) returns 400 on Fable 5.1, Mythos 5.1, Opus 5.5, Sonnet 5.5	auto, with strict tools and clear descriptions
Manual thinking budgets return 400 on 5.x models	Adaptive thinking, steered with effort
Non-default temperature, top_p, top_k return 400 (Opus 4.7 on, Haiku 5.5)	Grounding, examples, structured outputs
Cache reads cheaper: 0.05x on Opus and Sonnet 5.5, 0.025x on Fable 5.1	Caching matters even more

EXAM-SAFE

Forcing, tuning randomness and fixed budgets have given way to schemas, effort and grounding.

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Platform and tooling changes

DATE	CHANGE
28 Jul	MCP specification 2026-07-28: stateless, server/discover, sampling deprecated
17-18 Aug	Workbench retired; the Console's playground replaces it
19 Aug	Files API and Skills API generally available; computer use GA
30 Sep	Claude for Government generally available, FedRAMP High
Oct	Claude Code starts in auto mode from v2.1.283; MCP tools deferred
Oct	Priority Tier commitments no longer sold; standard is best-effort

EXAM-SAFE

The architecture you design with has not changed. The surfaces you configure it on have.

The Usage Policy update

- **Announced 8 October, effective 12 November 2026.**
- **Eleven high-risk areas,** including finance, credit, insurance, housing, employment and healthcare access.
- **A qualified person** must meaningfully review a high-risk recommendation, with authority to change it, before it is used.
- **Affected people** must be told AI was used.
- **Consumer chatbots and agents** must disclose they are AI, at least at the start of each session.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The substance matches what the course teaches: human authority, disclosure, transparency.

Already in scope: features from early 2026

DATE	FEATURE
29 Jan	Structured outputs generally available
5 Feb	Effort parameter generally available
17 Feb	Tool search tool generally available
19 Feb	Automatic prompt caching
8 Apr	Claude Managed Agents, public beta
11 May	Claude Platform on AWS

EXAM-SAFE

These predate the guide, so treat them as fully in scope, even if older study material omits them.

If a question asks you to...

GOAL	ANSWER WITH
Guarantee schema-valid output	Structured outputs or strict tools
Make outputs more consistent	Grounding, examples, schemas, evaluation
Use many MCP tools without bloat	Tool search with deferred loading
Move to a newer model	Check support, evaluate, re-baseline cost and latency
Act on a high-risk recommendation	Qualified human review before use
Lock down Claude Code for everyone	Managed settings

EXAM-SAFE

Each answer was right before the changes, and is still right after them.

> Tallyhawk's billing agent sets tool_choice to force its update_subscription tool.
>
> After moving to Opus 5.5, every request returns a 400 error.

What should the team change?

A. Use auto tool choice, keep the strict tool schema and a clear description, and validate the call in code

B. Pin the previous model permanently, so forced tool choice keeps working

C. Set temperature to zero, so the model always picks the same tool

D. Retry each failed request until the model accepts it

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team change?

A. Use auto tool choice, keep the strict tool schema and a clear description, and validate the call in code

Auto, strict schema, validation.

B. Pin the previous model permanently, so forced tool choice keeps working

Models retire; this only delays.

C. Set temperature to zero, so the model always picks the same tool

Also rejected, and not the mechanism.

D. Retry each failed request until the model accepts it

A 400 will never succeed.

THE SIGNAL

Forced tool choice is gone on current models. Strict tools, clear descriptions and code validation replace it.

> A Quillon engineer wants discharge summaries on Opus 5.5 to be more consistent.
>
> He proposes setting the temperature to zero.

What should Corvane advise?

A. Set the temperature to zero as proposed

B. Lower top p instead, which has a similar effect

C. Keep default sampling, and improve consistency with grounding, examples and structured outputs

D. Prefill the start of each summary to fix its wording

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane advise?

A Set the temperature to zero as proposed

Returns a 400 on this model.

B Lower top p instead, which has a similar effect

Also returns a 400.

C Keep default sampling, and improve consistency with grounding, examples and structured outputs

Grounding, examples, schemas.

D Prefill the start of each summary to fix its wording

Prefill also returns a 400.

THE SIGNAL

Sampling parameters and prefill are rejected on current models. Consistency comes from grounding, examples and schemas.

> From the twelfth of November, Mereside wants its assistant to send explanations of mortgage decisions directly to members.

What does the updated Usage Policy require?

A Nothing extra, provided accuracy on the evaluation set is high

B A note in the terms and conditions that AI may be used

C A human reviews a sample of explanations after they are sent

D A qualified person reviews each explanation, with authority to change it, before it is sent, and members are told AI was used

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What does the updated Usage Policy require?

A Nothing extra, provided accuracy on the evaluation set is high

Accuracy does not replace review.

B A note in the terms and conditions that AI may be used

Disclosure must be clear to the person.

C A human reviews a sample of explanations after they are sent

Review must come before use.

D A qualified person reviews each explanation, with authority to change it, before it is sent, and members are told AI was used

Qualified review before use, plus disclosure.

THE SIGNAL

High-risk areas need qualified human review before use, and the affected person must be told AI was used.

> After a Claude Code upgrade, Tallyhawk's sessions start in auto mode.
>
> Security wants nobody to use auto mode until its rules have been reviewed.

How should Corvane enforce that?

A. Disable auto mode in managed settings, and keep the existing deny and ask rules

B. Set the default mode to Manual in each repository's project settings

C. Add an instruction to every CLAUDE.md asking developers not to use auto mode

D. Ask developers to press Shift and Tab out of auto mode at the start of each session

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should Corvane enforce that?

A Disable auto mode in managed settings, and keep the existing deny and ask rules

Enforced everywhere, non-overridable.

B Set the default mode to Manual in each repository's project settings

Developers can still switch modes.

C Add an instruction to every CLAUDE.md asking developers not to use auto mode

Guidance, not enforcement.

D Ask developers to press Shift and Tab out of auto mode at the start of each session

Relies on every developer, every time.

THE SIGNAL

A non-negotiable control goes in managed settings: disableAutoMode.

> Tallyhawk's platform team runs a remote MCP server for help-centre search.
>
> They ask whether the July 2026 specification means redesigning their architecture.

What should Corvane tell them?

A. Replace MCP with direct API calls, since the protocol is unstable

B. Rebuild the server as an agent-to-agent service instead

C. Keep the architecture, update the server for the stateless protocol, and keep authorisation with no token passthrough

D. Stay on the old specification indefinitely to avoid any change

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane tell them?

A Replace MCP with direct API calls, since the protocol is unstable

Over-reacts to a protocol revision.

B Rebuild the server as an agent-to-agent service instead

A different pattern, not a fix.

C Keep the architecture, update the server for the stateless protocol, and keep authorisation with no token passthrough

Same architecture, updated protocol.

D Stay on the old specification indefinitely to avoid any change

Clients will move on.

THE SIGNAL

The architecture is unchanged. Update the implementation, and keep the security rules.

> Corvane is updating its internal briefing on changes since the July 2026 guide.

Which two statements are correct? Choose two.

A The newest Opus model still accepts forced tool choice

B The newest Haiku model rejects manual thinking budgets with an error

C Sonnet four point five retires on the thirtieth of November

D New Priority Tier commitments can still be bought for any model

E Fast mode is available on Amazon Bedrock

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two statements are correct? Choose two.

A The newest Opus model still accepts forced tool choice

Rejected with a 400.

B The newest Haiku model rejects manual thinking budgets with an error

Correct: 400 on 5.x.

C Sonnet four point five retires on the thirtieth of November

Correct, announced 30 September.

D New Priority Tier commitments can still be bought for any model

No longer sold.

E Fast mode is available on Amazon Bedrock

Claude API only.

THE SIGNAL

Check dated details against the release notes. Answer the principle on the exam.

> Mereside's document extraction runs on Amazon Bedrock and depends on schema-guaranteed JSON.
>
> The team wants to move it to Opus 5.5 next week.

What should Corvane do first?

A Switch, since structured outputs behave the same on every platform and model

B Check the platform's feature support for that model, then evaluate before switching

C Move the workload to the first-party API, where the newest features arrive first

D Replace structured outputs with forced tool choice on the new model

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do first?

A Switch, since structured outputs behave the same on every platform and model

Not true on Bedrock for this model.

B Check the platform's feature support for that model, then evaluate before switching

Check support, then evaluate.

C Move the workload to the first-party API, where the newest features arrive first

Breaks the UK or EU processing requirement.

D Replace structured outputs with forced tool choice on the new model

Rejected on the new model.

THE SIGNAL

Feature support varies by platform and model. Check it, then evaluate, before any switch.

> Tallyhawk classifies support tickets on Opus 5.5 and wants lower latency.
>
> An engineer proposes turning thinking off for the classifier.

What should Corvane recommend?

A. Set a minimal manual thinking budget for the classifier

B. Disable thinking on the new Opus model for these requests

C. Raise the max tokens limit so classification finishes sooner

D. Lower effort, or route classification to a smaller tier, and measure both on the evaluation set

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane recommend?

A Set a minimal manual thinking budget for the classifier

Manual budgets return a 400.

B Disable thinking on the new Opus model for these requests

Thinking cannot be disabled on this model.

C Raise the max tokens limit so classification finishes sooner

Limits output; does not speed it.

D Lower effort, or route classification to a smaller tier, and measure both on the evaluation set

Effort and tier are the levers.

THE SIGNAL

On current models, effort and tier are the speed levers. Measure the change on the evaluation set.

In five lines

- **Principles unchanged;** answer with them, use details to rule options out.
- **New models** Opus 5, Fable 5.1, Opus, Sonnet and Haiku 5.5; Sonnet 4.5 retires 30 Nov.
- **No forced tool choice, sampling tweaks or thinking budgets** on current models.
- **MCP 2026-07-28, auto mode, Claude for Government,** Priority Tier no longer sold.
- **Usage Policy from 12 Nov:** qualified review before use, and disclosure.

> COMING UP
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> Next: how CCAR-P questions are written.